

Department of Computer and Information Sciences CS958 – Project

Report Content, Style, and Layout

Academic Year 2025/2026

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1 Introduction

This document provides details about the project report content, style, and formatting. Before reading this document, please ensure you have already read the [Project Handbook](#) and the documents on [Dissertation Types](#).

2 Font

Submissions should use an 11- or 12-point font, 1.5 line spacing and have either indented paragraphs, or paragraphs separated by a single line or equivalent spacing. Leave a good margin all round. Use a font that is clear and easy on the eye (e.g. sans-serif fonts such as Arial, Calibri, and Verdana), and avoid exotic fonts such as those that represent handwriting.

3 Length of Dissertation

Dissertations should be approximately 10,000 words (+/- 10%) in length for all MSc programmes, except for MSc Software Development, for which a lower word count of no less than 8,000 words may be acceptable.. This word count relates to the body of the dissertation. It excludes the title page, declaration, abstract, acknowledgements, table of contents, list of illustrations, references, and appendices.

4 Structure

Dissertations should consist of the following parts, in the order given:

- Title page see Appendix 1
- Declaration signed and dated, see Appendix 2
- Abstract see Section 4.1, and Appendix 3
- Acknowledgements see Section 4.2
- Table of contents see Appendix 4
- List of illustrations see Section 4.3
- Dissertation proper see Section 4.4
- References see Section 4.5
- Appendices if appropriate

4.1 Abstract

The abstract is a short (up to one page) summary of the dissertation, its conclusions, findings, etc. It should not be a chapter-by-chapter description. An example of an abstract can be found in Appendix 3.

4.2 Acknowledgements

It is appropriate to acknowledge any special assistance received while preparing your dissertation, particularly if assistance came from outside organisations or individuals, but acknowledgements should be kept to the minimum necessary.

4.3 Figures, illustrations, etc.

Any illustrations, figures, charts, or diagrams should be placed in the text as close as possible to the first point at which they are mentioned. They should be drawn clearly, and each type of illustration should be numbered consecutively throughout the dissertation, e.g. Figure 1.1 - Figure 10.3, Table 1.1 - Table 6.4. Try to ensure, where possible, that illustrations and tables fit onto one page, and take care that they do not run over from the bottom of a page to the top of the next.

The source of illustrations (if taken from other works) should be given under the illustration, in the same style as references.

Exceptionally, many illustrations, each of which occupies a page, can be gathered into an appendix at the end of the dissertation. They should still be numbered consecutively, and the appendix should also be numbered.

4.4 Dissertation proper

It is anticipated that most dissertations will contain the following chapters:

- Introduction
- Literature review
- Methodology
- Analysis and findings
- Recommendations and conclusions

However, you should follow the advice of your supervisor. Chapters may be subdivided into sections and sub-sections but should not normally be subdivided any further (e.g. Chapter 2, Section 2.3, Sub-Section 2.3.3).

More details about the content and structure of each dissertation type are provided in the document [What is required for each dissertation type](#).

4.5 References

References should be made to any quotations given in the work, and to any concepts, ideas, facts, data, etc., which you derive from the work of others, whether in the form of quotation or not. References in the text should follow one of the referencing styles recommended by the University (e.g. Harvard style). Please refer to [the library's guidance](#) on referencing for further information. References which do not conform to an acceptable standard may need to be resubmitted with the necessary corrections and, as this could delay your graduation, you should get into the habit of citing in this way from the start. There are many online guides that you can consult if you need advice on referencing specific types of sources.

Provide details of the author(s), date, in brackets at the point of citation, with the page number if the reference is to a monograph, for example:

The call for a free flow of information between nations is laudable, but the flow is often dictated or controlled by the wealthiest countries and commercial organisations (Usher, 2006, p.52)

or:

As Usher (2006, p.52) has pointed out, the call for a free flow of information between nations is laudable, but the flow is often dictated or controlled by the wealthiest countries and commercial organisations.

Both citation styles are acceptable but choose one and be consistent in its application. You should provide a single alphabetically ordered list of works consulted or cited, with inclusive page numbers for articles, etc.

5 Quotations

Short quotations (up to 2 lines) should be incorporated into the text and enclosed in double quotation marks. Longer quotations should be placed as a separate indented paragraph, without quotation marks, for example:

Short quotation:

Drybrough (2002) suggests that "merely documenting procedures is insufficient; you must also have proof that you do what you say."

Long quotation:

In discussing the relationship between society and information technologies, Hamelink has pointed out that:

The question arises whether the historical process in which informatisation evolves from mechanisation implies fundamental changes in the social structures in which it takes place. To answer this, it is helpful to go back to that earlier phase in history which is commonly referred to as the industrial revolution (Hamelink, 1999, p.172).

In the case of long quotations, the reference should always be placed in brackets at the end of the quotation.

6 Page Numbering

Preliminary pages should be numbered in Roman numerals (i.e. I, II, III, IV, ...). Arabic numbering (i.e. 1, 2, 3, ...) should begin on the first page of the dissertation proper, i.e. the Introduction. Page numbers should be placed at the bottom centre of the page.

7 Paragraph Layout

Paragraphs may be formatted using either the indented style or the block style.

Example of indented style:

CHAPTER 1: EXPERT SYSTEMS: AN OVERVIEW

1.1 Introduction

The last few years have witnessed a dramatic growth of interest in the applications of expert systems (ES) across a wide spectrum of disciplines and professions...

Expert systems have risen to prominence because of four major inter-related factors...

1.1.1 ES application areas

Expert systems have been applied in a wide range of areas in many subjects and disciplines...

Example of block style:

CHAPTER 1: EXPERT SYSTEMS: AN OVERVIEW

1.1 Introduction

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Appendix 1 – Title Page Example

THE ORGANISATIONAL IMPACT OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY:
EFFECTS ON THE QUALITY OF WORKLIFE

HORACE BROON

This dissertation was submitted in part fulfilment of requirements for the degree of MSc
Information and Library Studies

DEPT. OF COMPUTER AND INFORMATION SCIENCES
UNIVERSITY OF STRATHCLYDE

SEPTEMBER 2012

Appendix 2 – Declaration Example

DECLARATION

This dissertation is submitted in part fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of MSc in Information and Library Studies of the University of Strathclyde.

I declare that this dissertation embodies the results of my own work and that it has been composed by myself.

Following normal academic conventions, I have made due acknowledgement to the work of others.

I declare that I have sought and received ethics approval via the Departmental Ethics Committee as appropriate to my research.

I give permission to the University of Strathclyde, Department of Computer and Information Sciences, to provide copies of the dissertation, at cost, to those who may in the future request a copy of the dissertation for private study or research.

I give permission to the University of Strathclyde, Department of Computer and Information Sciences, to place a copy of the dissertation in a publicly available archive.

(please tick) Yes [X] No []

I declare that the word count for this dissertation (excluding title page, declaration, abstract, acknowledgements, table of contents, list of illustrations, references and appendices, is 10,045.

I confirm that I wish this to be assessed as a Type 1 2 ③ 4 5 Dissertation (please circle).

Signature:

Date:

Appendix 3 – Abstract Example

ABSTRACT

In acknowledgement of the fact that people often experience a change in work values where modern technology is concerned, this research examines the effects that IT based systems have had upon users' feelings of job satisfaction. The organisation forming the context for the research is JLM whose Information Services Section at Harding, in Cumbria, has recently introduced two quite different IT based systems.

The aim of the research is to make a study of work values at both an organisational and individual level, to assess what it is that people expect to gain from satisfying work and to consider how these values alter, if at all, with the introduction of recent technology. The discussion examines the importance of integrating social organisational policies with technical policies in the management of future technology.

It was discovered that a considerable number of employees did experience an increase in job satisfaction following the introduction of the systems concerned. In some cases, this was related to use of the systems, in others to the resultant change in the nature of the work and its requirements of the individual. The increase in job satisfaction is attributed to the existence or fulfilment of certain work values and is found to occur most frequently where a certain number of employees' work values exist or are enhanced by the nature of the work. Thus technology, by bringing about change in the organisational social structure, can bring about change in the quality of work life.

Appendix 4 – Table of Contents Example

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